

KF Introduction to NHG

Chapter 4: *Neurotic Pride*¹

When we read about pride in the Bible, we can easily see that God is teaching us about neurotic, unhealthy pride. This pride exists only in our imagination; it is not based on real assets or evidence. As neurotics, we actually believe that our judgments, standards, expectations, and qualities are superior to those of others, including God's—and that's why neurotic pride is the kind of pride that God is forced to oppose. If God were to indiscriminately help us reach our potential while we were still committed to neurotic pride, we would not be able to recognize how our pride is killing us.

Although God opposes the proud, He gives grace to the humble. Who are the humble? They are those who choose to give up their neurotic pride and accept the reality of their strengths, weaknesses, and limitations. They are willing to learn how to stop wasting energy through controlling, competing, and comparing. Humble people receive grace from God. What is this grace? The Greek word for grace is *karis*. Karis Fellowships offers an expanded understanding of grace and trains us to live as allies of God. When people in the first century heard the good news of God's grace, they understood that their Creator had invited them into relationship with Himself through the gift of Jesus. With this understanding in mind, here is a paraphrase of First Peter 5:5-8.

⁵In the same way, you younger ones, place yourselves under the shelter of mature people. And all of you, bind yourselves up with humility in your dealings with each other for this very good reason: God stands against those who indulge in illusions of superiority, but to the humble He offers an invitation into a relationship with Himself. ⁶Be humble, therefore, under the strong hand of God so that He can raise you to real superiority at the appropriate time. ⁷God is concerned about you, so go ahead and cast all of your cares onto Him. You no longer need to use your pride to resolve them. ⁸Abstain from compulsive choices and behaviors. Refuse to live on autopilot, and stay awake because the devil, your opponent in the courtroom of your soul, pads around like a roaring lion seeking to swallow you up."

Take a deep breath.

In order to feel superior, we have to continually judge as good or bad both ourselves and others. Regardless of the evidence, we think that we know better, have the right answers, deserve more, have better intentions, are exempt from cause and effect, and have the best plan, not only for our own lives but for the lives of those around us. Our thoughts and ways are better than anyone else's, even God's.² Furthermore, we constantly, and often unconsciously, evaluate and judge our own thoughts, feelings, and choices, measuring them against our self-imposed standards. Our pride condemns us if we fail to fulfill those standards, and the fear of self-condemnation makes us chronically vigilant, rigid, anxious, and blind to possibilities. We become wildly defensive when our sense of security is challenged. Our self-esteem is on the line! Managing our proud standards requires a ton of energy. No wonder God warned Adam and Eve that tasting the fruit from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil would kill them!³

In our pride we compete with God, and like Adam and Eve, we firmly believe that we understand what is good and what is evil. We consider it our god-like duty to judge others and make them do what we think

they should do. If others fail to meet our standards, or we fail to mold them to our standards, our pride is hurt and we suffer beyond the realities of the situation. On the other hand, we may abdicate responsibility and believe that it is evil to influence others or change ourselves. We may not even attempt to learn basic life skills. Instead, we pridefully presume that God will take care of everything for us, and we congratulate ourselves on our “faith”. But when through passivity and avoidance our lives become unmanageable, our pride is hurt, and we feel intense anxiety. Neurotic pride makes us vulnerable to an absurd degree.

Pride makes us untrustworthy in every relationship, even our relationship with God. Our compelling need to measure others against our standards, justify our judgments, and protect our pride prevents us from accepting or acknowledging others as they actually are and hinders the growth of any real relationship. You can see why Horney says that pride is the enemy of love.

In the letters from Peter and James, we learn that pride and the devil go together. Pride feeds directly into the devil’s purposes, but there is an alternative to neurotic pride: you can learn to live in real humility, let go of the judgments of your pride system, and take the attitude of a learner with God as your Teacher. He would love to lift you up, if only you would let Him.⁴

¹ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).

² Isaiah 55:8–9.

³ Genesis 2:16–17.

⁴ 1 Peter 5:6–10; James 4:6–10.